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(c) The totals of the two sides of the balance sheet must be equal. If the totals are not equal, it indicates existence of error. It must satisfy the accounting equation, ie., Assets = Capital + Liabilities, following the dual aspect concept.

(d) Balance sheet is prepared on a particular date and not for a fixed period. It discloses the financial position of a business on a particular date. It gives the balances only for the date on which it is prepared.

(e) It shows the financial position of the business according to the going concern concept.

12.5.3 Grouping and Marshalling of assets and liabilities in a balance sheet

The assets and liabilities shown in the balance sheet are grouped and presented in a particular order. The term 'grouping' means showing the items of similar nature under a common heading. For example, the amount due from various customers will be shown under the head 'Sundry debtors.' Similarly, under the head 'Current assets', the balance of cash, bank, debtors, stock and other current assets will be shown.

'Marshalling' is the arrangement of various assets and liabilities in a proper order. Marshalling can be made in one of the following two ways:

(a) In the order of liquidity

According to this method, an asset which is most easily convertible into cash, i.e., cash in hand is shown first and then will follow those assets which are comparatively less easily convertible, so that the least liquid asset i.e., goodwill is shown last. In the same way, the liabilities which are to be paid at the earliest will be shown first. In other words, current liabilities are shown first, then fixed or long-term liabilities and finally the proprietor's capital.

(b) In the order of permanence

This method is exactly the reverse of the first method. Asset which is more permanent, i.e., goodwill is shown first followed by assets which are less permanent. Similarly, those liabilities which are to be paid last will be shown first. In other words, the proprietor's capital is shown first, then fixed or long-term liabilities and lastly the current liabilities. Joint stock companies are required under the Companies Act to prepare their balance sheet in the order of permanence.

12.5.4 Methods of drafting a balance sheet

The balance sheet of business concern can be presented in the following two forms.

a) Horizontal form

b) Vertical form